



Multiculturalism

Multicultural Communication

- International business requires multicultural communication, the sharing of written or oral information between businesspeople from many different countries.
- According to one recent study, 67% of professionals communicate internationally.

TABLE 4.4 Global Communication

Company	Impact
Black & Veatch	Black & Veatch, a global engineering company, has locations in Argentina, Australia, Botswana, Brazil, China, the Czech Republic, Egypt, Germany, Hong Kong, India, Indonesia, Korea, Kuwait, Malaysia, Mexico, Philippines, Poland, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, South Africa, Swaziland, Taiwan, Thailand, Turkey, United Arab Emirates, United Kingdom, United States, Vietnam, Zambia, and Zimbabwe.
Cerner	As a global supplier of healthcare solutions, Cerner works with more than 8,000 clients worldwide and has locations in the United States, Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Hong Kong, India, Ireland, Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, Malaysia, Singapore, Spain, United Arab Emirates, and the United Kingdom.
Coca Cola	Coca Cola produces 400 different brands in 200 countries. Seventy-five percent of their income is generated from outside the United States (Coca-Cola Company).
Hallmark Cards	Margaret Keating, vice president-operations for Hallmark Cards Inc., oversees Hallmark's North American manufacturing and distribution, graphics, global procurement, and global operations. She says, "Communication is critical with a group [of 6,000 employees] geographically dispersed." "She spends a lot of time making communication clear, concise and compelling. That it has to be translated into different languages makes efficient communication even more important." Technical communication at Hallmark "has to make sense to the audience, and the audiences are very different" (Cardarella).

Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

Define Acronyms and abbreviation

- For example, corporate employees often abbreviate the job title “system manager” as “sysmgr”
- However, in German the title “system manager” is called the “system leiter”
- In French, it’s “le responsable”
- The abbreviation “sysmgr” would make no sense in either of these countries.

Avoid Jargon and Idioms

ballpark figure

eye on the prize

belt-tightening

face the music

bite the bullet

guesstimate

brownie points

jump through hoops

buck stops here

pass the buck

crunch time

pull the plug

dog-eat-dog world

shape up or ship out

drum up business

through the roof

Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

Distinguish Between Nouns and Verbs

- Computer terms usually act as both nouns and verbs. For example
- File, scroll, paste, help, boot, code

Watch for Cultural Biases/Expectations

Be Careful When Using Slash Marks

- Does the slash mark mean “and”, “or” or both “and/ or”

Avoid Humour and Pun



Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

Realize That
Translations May
Take More or Less
Space

Avoid Figurative
Language

TABLE 4.5 Translations Increase Word Length

English Word	Translations into Other Languages
Print	Impression (French)
File	Archivo (Spanish)
View	Visualizzare (Italian)
Help	Assistance (French)
E-mail	Courriel (Swiss)

Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

- Be Careful with Numbers, Measurements, Date and Time

TABLE 4.6 Different Ways of Understanding and Writing the U.S. Date 05/03/12

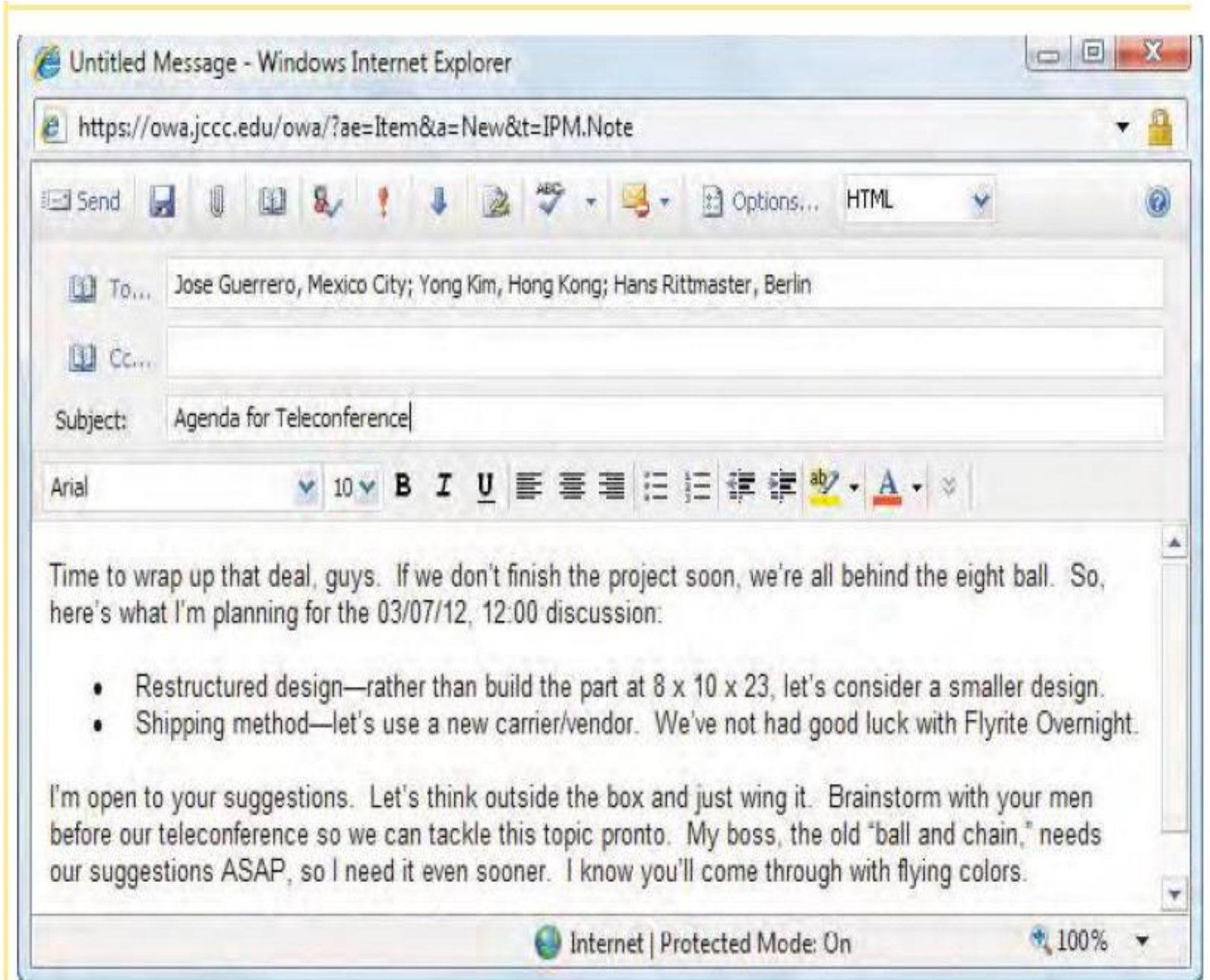
Country	Date
United States	May 3, 2012
United Kingdom	March 5, 2012
France	5 mars 2012
Germany	5. Marz 2012
Sweden	12-05-03
Italy	5.3.12

TABLE 4.7 Different Ways of Writing the U.S. Time 5:15 P.M.

Country	Time
United States	5:15 P.M.
France	17:15
Germany	17.15
Quebec, Canada	17 h 15

Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

- Use Stylized Graphics to Represent People



This e-mail fails for many reasons:

1. Date. Does “03/07/12” mean March 7, 2012 or July 3, 2012?
2. Time. “12:00” not only fails to specify the time zone, but also creates the question whether midnight or noon is intended.
3. Figurative language. “Wrap up that deal,” “behind the eight ball,” “think outside the box,” “just wing it,” “brainstorm,” “tackle the topic,” “ball and chain,” and “flying colors” all are idiomatic phrases. Though these phrases might communicate within the United States, they may not translate internationally.
4. Informal tone. Informality is common in most stateside businesses, but this is not true in all countries. Germany and Japan, for example, are far more formal in their technical communication expectations. Thus, “guys” and the contractions could cause problems creating incorrect tone.
5. Sexist language. “Guys” and “men” should be avoided when writing any correspondence. The implication is that only men will be involved in the discussions.

6. Measurements. “ $8 \times 10 \times 23$ ” is confusing. Is the writer discussing inches, feet, or meters?
7. Slash marks. “New carrier/vendor” could mean either “new carrier *or* vendor,” or “new carrier *and* vendor.” Which is it?
8. Undefined abbreviations or acronyms. “ASAP” must be defined. Though all readers within the United States might understand this to mean “as soon as possible,” you cannot assume the same level of understanding internationally.
9. Cultural sensitivity. In the United States, we might see humor in referring to a boss as “the old ball and chain” (though this is highly doubtful). In Japan, however, where saving face is a cultural norm, potentially offending a superior would be a problem. Finally, “pronto” is cowboy slang. To communicate internationally, you must consider each country’s cultural norms—and be careful to avoid offense or confusion.

To... Jose Guerrero, Mexico City; Yong Kim, Hong Kong; Hans Rittmaster, Berlin

Cc...

Subject: Agenda for Teleconference

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We need to complete our team project. Doing so will allow our respective companies to meet our client's deadline. A teleconference is our best way to communicate, given everyone's diverse locations. I have made all the technical arrangements. The teleconference is scheduled for March 7, 2012, at 12:00 noon, Pacific standard time. This is the only time that is at least somewhat convenient for all of us. During the teleconference, we will discuss the following:

- Restructured design—rather than build the part at 8" x 10" x 23" as planned (all dimensions in inches), we should consider a smaller design.
- Shipping method—a new carrier or vendor might save us money and time. Flyrite Overnight has increased its shipping fees by 25 percent. What do you think? I am open to your creative ideas.

Discuss these ideas with your coworkers before our teleconference so we can use our time effectively. My boss, Sue Cottrell, needs our suggestions by March 8, 2012, 4:00 P.M. central standard time. With your help, I know our company will make the correct decisions.

Leonard Liss
1212 W. 148th
New York, NY 10101
1-800-555-1212



Internet | Protected Mode: On



100%



Guidelines for Effective Multicultural Communication

- Avoiding Biased Language
- Ageist Language
- Biased Language About People With Disabilities

BEFORE

Professor Jones, an elderly teacher at State University, is publishing a textbook despite his age.

AFTER

Professor Jones, a State University teacher, is publishing a textbook.

BEFORE

Debbie Brown, a blind market researcher, won "Employee of the Month."

The AIDS victim changed insurance carriers.

John suffers from diabetes.

Sheila is confined to a wheelchair.

AFTER

Debbie Brown, a market researcher, won "Employee of the Month."

The AIDS patient changed insurance carriers.

John is diabetic.

Sheila uses a wheelchair.

Avoiding Biased Language

- Sexist Language
 - Ignoring Women or Treating Them as Secondary
- Stereotyping

BEFORE

Biased

The CEO of Yahoo is a woman named Carol A. Bartz.

When setting up his experiment, the researcher must always check for errors.

As we acquired scientific knowledge, men began to examine long-held ideas more critically.

AFTER

Unbiased

The CEO of Yahoo is Carol A. Bartz.

When setting up experiments, the researcher must always check for errors.

As we acquired scientific knowledge, people began to examine long-held ideas more critically.

BEFORE

Biased

Current tax regulations allow a head of household to deduct for the support of his children.

The manager is responsible for the productivity of his department; the foreman is responsible for the work of his linemen.

The administrative assistant brought her boss his coffee.

The teacher must be sure her lesson plans are filed.

AFTER

Unbiased

Current tax regulations allow a head of household to deduct for child support.

Management is responsible for departmental productivity. Supervisors are responsible for their personnel.

The administrative assistant brought the boss's coffee.

The teacher must file all lesson plans.

Avoid Biased Language

- Sexist Language
 - Pronouns
 - Gender Tagged Nouns

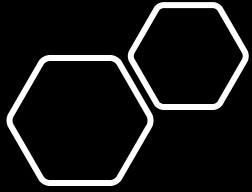
BEFORE	AFTER
Gender-tagged, Biased Nouns	Unbiased
mankind	people
manpower	workers, personnel
the common man	the average citizen
wise men	leaders
businessmen	businesspeople
policemen	police officers
firemen	firefighters
foreman	supervisor
chairman	chairperson, chair
stewardess/steward	flight attendant
waitress/waiter	server

BEFORE	AFTER
Biased	Unbiased
Sometimes the doctor calls on his patients in their homes.	Sometimes the doctor calls on patients in their homes.
The typical child does his homework after school.	Most children do their homework after school.
A good lawyer will make sure that his clients are aware of their rights.	A good lawyer will make sure that clients are aware of their rights.

Audience Involvement

- Personalized Tone
 - Pronouns
 - Names





Audience Involvement

- Reader Benefit
 - Explain the benefit
 - Use Positive Words
 - We cannot process your request. You failed to follow the printed information.
 - So that we may process your request rapidly, please fill in line 6 on the printed form.
 - We have received your letter complaining about our services.
 - Thank you for writing to us about our services.

Activity

Avoiding Sexist Language

1. Revise the following sentences to avoid sexist language.
 - a. All the software development specialists and their wives attended the conference.
 - b. The foremen met to discuss techniques for handling union grievances.
 - c. Every technician must keep accurate records for his monthly activity reports.
 - d. The president of the corporation, a woman, met with her sales staff.
 - e. Throughout the history of mankind, each scientist has tried to make his mark with a discovery of significant intellectual worth.

Activity (answers)

- a) All the software development specialists and their spouses attend the conference.
- b) The supervisors met to discuss techniques for handling union grievances.
- c) Every technician must keep accurate records for monthly activity reports.
- d) The president of the corporation met with the sales staff.
- e) Throughout the history of people, scientists have tried to make their mark with a discovery of significant intellectual worth.

Any Questions?

